management of nature and its resources is termed as **conservation**.

We have to build a sustainable world, which should last forever. Some of the ways to sustain continuous use of resources are practices to utilise energy efficiently, avoid wastage of water, avoid usage of plastics and other non-biodegradable materials and to take care for the environment we live. It is important that we manage and use our resources carefully so as to preserve for the future generations.

22.2 Forest and its Importance

Forests are an important component of our environment and are dominated by microorganisms, flowering plants, shrubs, climbers, dense trees and provide a vast habitat for wild animals. Forests also contribute to the economic development of our country. Forests are vital for human life, it is a source for a wide range of **renewable natural resource**. They provide wood, food, fodder, fibre and medicine.

Forests are major factor of environmental concern. They act as carbon sink, regulate climatic conditions, increase rainfall, reduce global warming, prevent natural hazards like flood and landslides, protect wildlife and also act as catchments for water conservation. They also play a vital role in maintaining the ecological balance.

22.2.1 Deforestation and its Effects

Deforestation is the destruction of large area of forests. This happens for many reasons like intensive agriculture, urbanization, construction of dams, roads, buildings and industries, hydroelectric projects, forest fires, construction of mountain and forest roads. It is a threat to the economy, quality of life and future of the environment. India is losing about 1.5 million hectares of forest cover every year.

More to Know

Chipko movement

The Chipko movement was a non-violent agitation in 1973 that was aimed at protection and conservation of trees. The name of the movement '**Chipko**' comes from the word 'embrace', as the villagers hugged the trees and encircled them to prevent them from being cut. The movement originated in the Chamoli district of Uttar Pradesh (now Uttarakhand). The protest of Chipko movement achieved a major victory in 1980 with a 15 year ban on cutting trees in the Himalayan forests.

Effects of Deforestation

Deforestation gives rise to ecological problems like floods, drought, soil erosion, loss of wild life, extinction of species, imbalance of biogeochemical cycles, alteration of climatic conditions and desertification.

22.2.2 Conservation of Forests

India has an area of 752.3 lakh hectare classified as **reserved forests** and 215.1 lakh hectare as **protected forests**. The important measures taken for conservation of forests are as follows

Afforestation: Activities for afforestation programme (**Van Mahotsav**) includes planting and protecting trees with multiple uses which help in restoration of green cover. Destruction of trees should be curtailed.

Social forestry programme: It should be undertaken on a large scale with active participation of the public and utilization of common land to produce firewood, fodder and timber for the benefit of the rural community. This relieves pressure on existing forests and to safeguard future of tribals.

Forest Conservation through Laws: Adopting stringent laws and policies to conserve and protect forests are through National Forest Policy, (1952 and 1988) and Forest Conservation Act, 1980.

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